

New Additions to India's UNESCO Tentative List



Source: AIR

Why in News?

The Ministry of Culture and Tourism announced the inclusion of **five new heritage properties and serial transnational proposals** to **India's UNESCO Tentative List** . With these new additions, India's total count on the Tentative List has increased to **78** .

What are the Key Facts About the Newly Added Sites to India's UNESCO Tentative List?

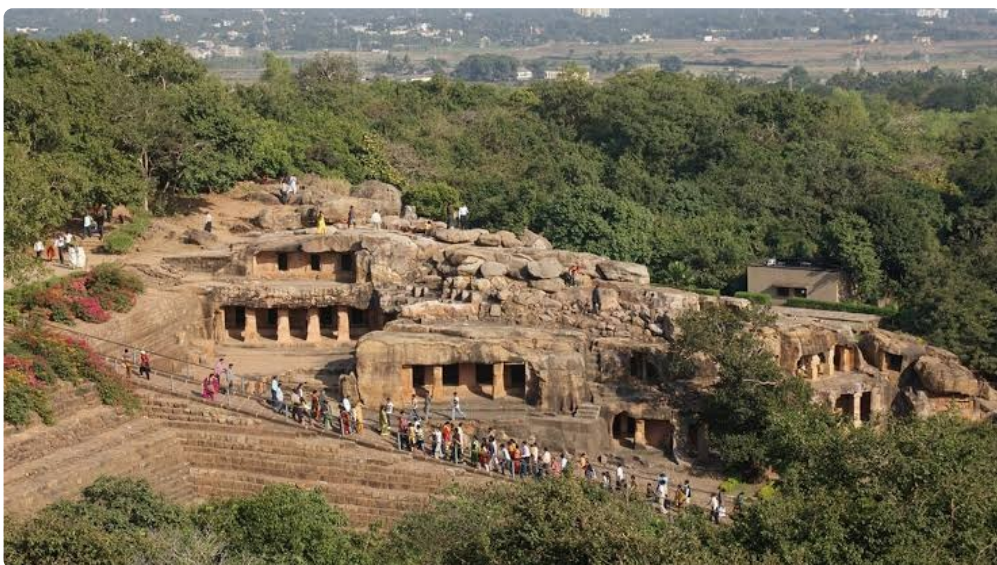
Bagh Cave Paintings (Madhya Pradesh)

- **Geographical Uniqueness:** Situated on the southern slopes of the **Vindhyan range** along the **Baghni river** , this site comprises nine rock-cut **Buddhist caves** carved into the **only sandstone outcrop** in an otherwise basaltic region.
- **Chronology and Political Significance:** Developed during the **Gupta period (4th-6th century CE)** .
 - Ancient inscriptions (358 to 487 AD) use terms like "**Valkha**" and "**Vikha-adishthana**" (powerbase of chieftdom), proving the site was a major **political and administrative center** , not merely an isolated retreat.
- **Monastic Importance:** Associated with the **Buddhist monk Dattaka** , the complex functioned as a major **Buddhist monastic retreat** , featuring *Chaityagrihas* (assembly halls), *Viharas* (residential cells), pillared verandas, and *Stupas* .
- **Mural Painting Techniques:** The murals demonstrate **technical continuity with the Ajanta Caves** , while retaining a distinct regional artistic identity. They used **earth and lime-based plasters** and mineral pigments such as **lapis lazuli, terre verte, red and yellow ochre, and carbon** .
 - Bagh's murals form part of India's wider mural-painting tradition alongside **Ajanta** , and can be compared with major mural traditions such as **Sigiriya in Sri Lanka** and **Mogao in China** .



Udaigiri Caves (Madhya Pradesh)

- **Chronology & Patronage:** Excavated primarily between the **late 4th and early 5th centuries CE** , the site contains **twenty rock-cut caves** commissioned under the reigns of Gupta emperors **Chandragupta II and Kumaragupta I** .
- **Iconographic Masterpieces:** Renowned for classical **Vaishnava iconography** , most notably the colossal **Varaha panel** (symbolizing divine rescue of Prithvi/Bhudevi, cosmic restoration, and royal sovereignty) and the reclining **Anantasayana Vishnu** .
- **Religious Co-existence:** While predominantly dedicated to **Vaishnavism and Shaivism** , the ensemble also features **Jain excavations** , reflecting the religious pluralism of the Gupta period.
- **Architectural Transition:** Represents the pivotal bridge between early **monolithic rock-cut traditions** and later **freestanding stone temples** (featuring a carved sanctum, *mandapa* , and axial entrance planning).
- **Artistic Synthesis:** Reflects an artistic fusion of **Mathura and Malwa regional styles** with standard **Gupta classical aesthetics** , creating a template that influenced temple architecture across northern and central India.



Group of Temples of the Chambal Valley (Madhya Pradesh)

- **Historical & Dynastic Link:** The Group of Temples of the Chambal Valley - comprising **Bateshwar, Padavali, and Kakarmath** in the Morena district of Madhya Pradesh.

- Built between the **8 th and 11 th centuries CE** , these monuments illustrate the evolution of regional architecture under the patronage of the **Gurjara-Pratihara and Kachchhapaghata dynasties** .
- **Architectural Style:** The complexes represent an outstanding example of regional **Nagara-style temple architecture** .
 - Key features include **axial temple planning, prominent *shikharas* (spires), elaborate sandstone carvings** , and advanced **dry masonry construction** (precisely interlocked stone blocks built entirely without mortar).



Ginnorgarh Fort (Madhya Pradesh)

- **Location:** A tribal hill-fort strategically situated inside the **Ratapani Wildlife Sanctuary** , utilizing dense forests, ravines, and steep slopes as natural defense mechanisms.
- **Historical Significance:** It served as the principal fortified capital of the **Raj Gond rulers of the Garha Kingdom** between the 15 th and 18 th centuries.
- **Link to Rani Durgavati:** Following the fall of the legendary Gond queen **Rani Durgavati in 1564 CE** , the region came under **Mughal control** but retained deep-rooted local Gond influence, creating a layered political history.
- **Tripartite Spatial Organization:** The fort reflects a highly sophisticated tribal social and military hierarchy, divided into three zones:
 - **Morcha:** The outermost defensive and service zone.

- **Amghera:** The middle administrative and military residential zone.
- **Inner Royal Core:** The innermost zone housing palaces and elite residences.
- **Indigenous Building Techniques:** It features ruins of the Rani Mahal—with rare Gond courtly wall paintings.
 - Construction utilized locally sourced stone, lime, and **surkhi** , uniquely bound together with **organic binders like natural jaggery and Bael pulp** .
- **Cultural Synthesis:** The site represents a unique hybrid architecture where indigenous Gond planning absorbed **Mughal/Indo-Islamic elements** , such as **engrailed arches and multi-faceted pillars** .



Rangpur-Sivasagar Historical Ensemble (Assam)

- **Historical Context:** The Rangpur-Sivasagar Historical Ensemble represents the political, ceremonial, and architectural heart of the Tai Ahom kingdom in Assam.
 - Led by **Siu-ka-pha** , the Tai Ahoms entered Assam from present-day Myanmar in **1228 CE** and ruled the Brahmaputra Valley for 600 years.
 - They successfully resisted Mughal expansion (notably the **Battle of Saraighat in 1671**) before declining due to Burmese invasions and British annexation via the **Treaty of Yandaboo (1826)**.
 - The ensemble centers on **Rangpur** (established as the Ahom capital in 1704) and **Sivasagar** , the later political and cultural hub.
- **Architectural Evolution:** Ahom architecture transitioned from **wood and bamboo to permanent brick-and-stone construction** .
 - Ahom temples (*Dols*) feature an **octagonal plinth (reflecting Ahom cosmology)** topped by a distinctive **hybrid shikhara (spire)** .
- **Advanced Hydraulic Engineering:** The Ahoms built massive reservoirs (Joysagar, Gaurisagar, and Sivasagar) using the **Paik system (a form of corvée labor)**.
 - They employed sophisticated indigenous technologies, including the **Nagastambha** (a wooden pillar driven into the ground to locate the water source) and surrounding moats (yamunas) to regulate water levels, ensure year-round supply, and prevent structural erosion.
- **Key Monuments**
 - **Rang Ghar:** One of Asia's oldest surviving amphitheatres, with an inverted Ahom boat-shaped roof, used for royal sports and Rongali Bihu celebrations.
 - **Talatal Ghar (Kareng Ghar):** A royal palace and military citadel with four above-ground and three

underground levels.

- **Ghanashyam House:** A Bengali atachala-style (eight-roofed) structure combining terracotta decoration with Islamic architectural elements.
- **Unique Infrastructure:** The ensemble includes **Pohugarh (regarded as Asia's first natural open-air zoo)** and the **Namdang Stone Bridge (built in 1703)** , constructed largely from a **single stone monolith using traditional organic mortar** , showcasing Ahom engineering resilience against **floods and earthquakes** .

Sites of Satyagraha (Serial Transnational Proposal)

- **Transnational Scope:** Proposed as a serial transnational property comprising nine components — **two in South Africa, representing Gandhi's 21-year stay (1893-1914), and seven in India**, tracing the geographical spread and evolution of the **Satyagraha movement**.
- **Inception and Exploratory Phase (South Africa)**
 - **Pietermaritzburg Station:** Site of Gandhi's **1893 eviction from a first-class train** , a pivotal experience in his fight against racial discrimination.
 - **Phoenix Settlement:** Founded in **1904** , Gandhi's first ashram settlement and the base for *Indian Opinion* , promoting **truth and Ahimsa (non-violence)** .
- **Consolidation Phase (India)**
 - **Champaran, Bihar:** Site of **Gandhi's first Satyagraha in India (1917)** .
 - **Sabarmati Ashram, Gujarat:** Established in **1917** and associated with the **1930 Dandi March (Salt Satyagraha)** .
 - **Mani Bhavan, Mumbai:** Gandhi's base during **1917-1934** , associated with major movements including **Non-Cooperation and Civil Disobedience** .
- **Institutionalization Phase (India)**
 - **Harijan Sevak Sangh, Delhi:** Founded in **1932** to promote **social equality and combat untouchability** .
 - **Sevagram Ashram, Wardha:** Established in **1936** , focusing on **rural development, self-reliance and Swaraj** .
 - **Aga Khan Palace, Pune:** Served as Gandhi's detention site during **1942-44** ; associated with **Kasturba Gandhi and Mahadev Desai's samadhis** .
 - **Gandhi Smriti, Delhi:** Gandhi's **last residence** , where he was assassinated on **30 th January 1948** .

UNESCO Tentative List

- **About:** The Tentative List is an inventory of cultural and natural heritage sites that a State Party considers to be of outstanding universal value and suitable for inscription on the **World Heritage List**.
- **Significance:** Inclusion on the Tentative List is a mandatory prerequisite. According to UNESCO guidelines, a site must remain on the Tentative List for at least **one year** before it can be officially nominated for World Heritage status.
- **Current Status for India:** With these additions, India now boasts 78 sites on the Tentative List.
 - India currently has **43 inscribed World Heritage Sites** (following recent additions like Santiniketan, the Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas, and Assam's Moidams).

Drishti Mains Question:

The proposed “Sites of Satyagraha” as a transnational serial heritage property reflects the cross-border evolution of Gandhi’s philosophy of Satyagraha. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the UNESCO Tentative List?

It is an inventory of sites considered by a **State Party to have potential Outstanding Universal Value (OUV)** and which may subsequently be nominated for the World Heritage List.

2. Why is the Tentative List important for UNESCO World Heritage nomination?

A site generally needs to be included in the State Party’s **Tentative List before nomination** to the World Heritage List, making it an important preparatory stage in the inscription process.

3. What makes the Rangpur-Sivasagar Historical Ensemble significant?

It showcases **Tai Ahom urban planning, temple architecture, hydraulic engineering and royal infrastructure**, including **Rang Ghar, Talatal Ghar and major reservoirs**.

4. What is the significance of the Sites of Satyagraha proposal?

It is a **serial transnational proposal linking heritage sites in South Africa and India**, tracing the development of Gandhi’s philosophy and practice of **Satyagraha and Ahimsa**.

5. What architectural features are associated with the Group of Temples of the Chambal Valley?

The Bateshwar, Padavali and Kakarmath temples showcase **early medieval Nagara architecture**, including **shikharas, axial planning, sandstone carvings and dry masonry construction**.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/3w4bGVpMxSA](https://www.youtube.com/embed/3w4bGVpMxSA)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Which one of the following statements with regard to the Moidams, built by the Tai-Ahom kingdom and inscribed as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO, is/are correct? (2026)

1. They acted as army fortresses.
2. They were recreation centres of the Royals and Nobles.
3. They were burial grounds of the Royals and Nobles.
4. They were battle drill centres of the Royals and Nobles.

Select the answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 1 and 3
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 4

Ans: C

Q. Consider the following properties included in the World Heritage List released by UNESCO: (2024)

1. Shantiniketan
2. Rani-ki-Vav
3. Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas
4. Mahabodhi Temple Complex at Bodhgaya

How many of the above properties were included in 2023?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) Only three
- (d) All four

Ans: (b)

Mains :

Q1. Safeguarding the Indian Art Heritage is the need of the moment. Discuss. **(2018)**

Q2. Indian Philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss. **(2020)**

28th Session of the FAO Committee on Forestry (COFO 28)



Source: PIB

India highlighted its significant achievements in sustainable forest management, ecological restoration, and climate action at the **28 th Session of the Food and Agriculture Organization's (FAO) Committee on Forestry (COFO 28) in Rome, Italy.**

- **Committee on Forestry (COFO):** COFO is the highest-level global intergovernmental statutory body on forestry within the FAO structure.
 - It brings together 128 FAO Members and meets **biennially at the FAO headquarters in Rome** to identify emerging policy and technical issues, seek solutions, and advise the FAO and its member nations on effective sustainable forest management.
 - It plays a crucial role in shaping agendas for the **UN Decade on Ecosystem Restoration (2021-2030)** and the **proposed UN Decade for Afforestation and Reforestation (2027-2036)**.
 - The COFO 28 session focused on the theme of **"Forests for food, resilience and prosperity"**, allowing India to present its progress on global climate commitments, biodiversity finance, and landscape restoration.
 - India highlighted **Sustainable Forest Management (SFM) as an integrated framework for landscape-level restoration** while considering national circumstances and local community needs.

India's Key Forestry and Restoration Achievements

- **Forest and Tree Cover:** **India's total forest and tree cover** has reached **82.74 million hectares** , encompassing **25.17%** of the nation's geographical landmass.
- **Global Rankings:** According to the **FAO's Global Forest Resources Assessment (FRA) 2025** , India ranks **9 th globally** in total forest area and **3 rd globally** in net annual forest area gain.
- **The Bonn Challenge:** India committed to restoring 26 million hectares of degraded and deforested land by 2030.
 - Currently, **21.76 million hectares** have already been brought under active restoration.
- **Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs):** India successfully created an **additional carbon sink of 2.29 billion tonnes of CO2 equivalent by 2021**. India ranked 5th among the top global carbon sinks, with its forests removing **150 Mt of CO₂ per year during 2021-2025**.
 - **India's Nationally Determined Contribution (2031-2035)** upgraded its target to achieve a cumulative sink of **3.5 to 4.0 billion tonnes** by 2035 (relative to 2005 levels).
- **Targeted Landscape Initiatives:**
 - **Aravalli Green Wall Project:** Identified approximately 6.45 million hectares of degraded arid land across Gujarat, Rajasthan, Haryana, and Delhi for eco-restoration to combat **eastern desertification**.
 - **MISHTI:** The **Mangrove Initiative for Shoreline Habitats & Tangible Incomes** is actively restoring coastal ecosystems to bolster climate resilience and local livelihoods.
 - **Wetland Conservation:** India successfully expanded its domestic network of internationally recognized **Ramsar Sites to 101 designated wetlands**.

- **Mass Mobilization:** The [Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam \(Plant4Mother\)](#) campaign was highlighted as a **whole-of-society initiative**, mobilizing nationwide participation to plant over 3.5 billion saplings.

Read more: [Reinventing Forest Conservation Efforts in India](#)

207th Birth Anniversary of Pandit Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar



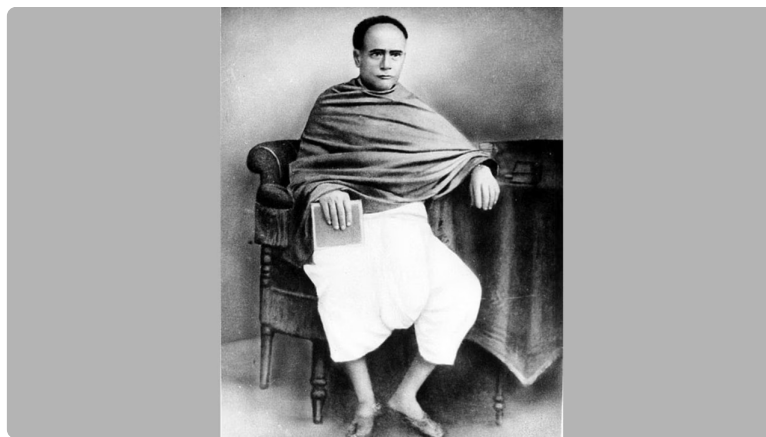
Source: AIR

On **26 th September 2026**, India observed the **207 th birth anniversary of Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar** , the eminent social reformer, philosopher, educationist, and polymath of the **Bengal Renaissance** , whose pioneering efforts in **vernacular education, women’s rights, and social reform** helped transform 19th-century Indian society.

- **Early Life & Scholarship:** Born in 1820 in West Bengal, he enrolled at **Sanskrit College in 1829** . He mastered Vedanta, Hindu law, and Western philosophy, earning the title **“Vidyasagar” (Sea of Knowledge)** at age 21.
- **Institutional Leadership:** He began his career as **head pandit at Fort William College** and later became the **Principal of Sanskrit College in 1851** , using these platforms to reimagine Indian education.
- **Educational Modernization:** Rejecting **elitist exclusivity** , he championed mass education in the vernacular, established numerous schools for girls, and authored ***Barnaparichay (Introduction to Letters)*** to standardize the Bengali alphabet.
 - **He reconstructed and simplified the Bengali alphabet** into **12 vowels and 40 consonants** , removing unnecessary Sanskrit phonemes.
 - His primer **‘Barnaparichay’** remains a foundational text for learning the Bengali alphabet.
- **Promotion of Women's Education:** He was a pioneer of female education in India. Collaborating with **Drinkwater Bethune** (an English educator), he helped establish the **Hindu Female School in 1849 (now Bethune College)**.
- **Opposition to child marriage** : Through writings in **Sarva Subhakari (1850)**, he criticised child marriage on social, ethical, and health grounds.
- **Widow Remarriage Act (1856):** Drawing upon **Smriti texts** to prove scriptures did not prohibit the practice, his 1855 pamphlets and formal petition culminated in the British government passing the [Hindu Widows’ Remarriage Act \(Act XV\) in 1856](#) (drafted during the tenure of Lord Dalhousie and enacted by Lord Canning).
- **Crusade Against Polygamy:** Combining rationalism with scriptural analysis, he led massive petition

campaigns in 1857 and 1866 (gathering tens of thousands of signatures) to suppress **Kulin Brahmin polygamy** (marital and social system in Bengal where high-ranking Brahmin men married numerous wives).

- **Pan-India Influence:** Vidyasagar carried forward the reformist legacy of **Raja Ram Mohan Roy** by combining rational thought with scriptural interpretation.
 - His writings and legislative victories inspired future reformers across India, including **Jyotirao Phule and Vishnu Shastri Pandit** , making him a foundational figure in India's intellectual and moral history.



Read more: [In Depth - Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar](#)

Jharkhand's Traditional Musical Instrument Mandar Gets GI Tag



Source: AIR

The traditional musical instrument **Mandar of Jharkhand** has received the **Geographical Indication (GI) tag** from the **Geographical Indications Registry, Chennai** , recognising its unique geographical, cultural and traditional identity.

- **About:** Mandar is a traditional **percussion instrument deeply associated with Jharkhand's tribal culture** , folk performances, community gatherings and celebrations.
- **Distinctive Features:** The GI application highlighted Mandar's **traditional craftsmanship, use of locally sourced red soil, indigenous manufacturing techniques and unique sound quality** as key factors supporting its recognition.
- **Unique Manufacturing Process:** Unlike instruments such as **dhol or dholak** , Mandar has distinct features, including one side of the instrument being made entirely from **soil** , which contributes to its

unique sound and design.

- **Economic Significance:** The GI status provides legal protection and a distinct identity to traditional Mandar artisans, helping expand market opportunities and promote Jharkhand's cultural products nationally and internationally.
- **Previous GI Recognition:** Jharkhand has also received GI recognition for other traditional products, including **Sohrai-Khovar painting** (the state's first GI-tagged product) and **Koderma's Kesariya Kalakand** .



Read More: [Geographical Indications in India](#)